

2026 North Alabama Undergraduate Writing Conference Proposal

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Interviewing my Grandfather: Curiosity is Crucial

Learning from the mistakes we make in life is essential to our growth. Even more essential is learning from the mistakes our elders have made, retaining and applying their wisdom in our own lives. In my researched-based personal essay, I share my grandfather's personal experience and wisdom about the importance of curiosity, the ability to learn anything through reading, and the value of historical knowledge.

I begin my essay by introducing my grandfather, Samuel Uptain, and explaining to the reader about his extensive education and professional experience. However, in many areas of his life, he did not have a teacher or any formal training. I then share with the reader my grandfather's recipe for success when lacking a teacher. The next sections are extensions to his recipe and dive into my grandfather's perspective on the importance of reading and knowing history, both relating perfectly to "Our History, Our Stories."

My personal essay heavily focuses on the importance of curious, self-taught learning, and I believe my story fits well within the scope of the conference's theme.